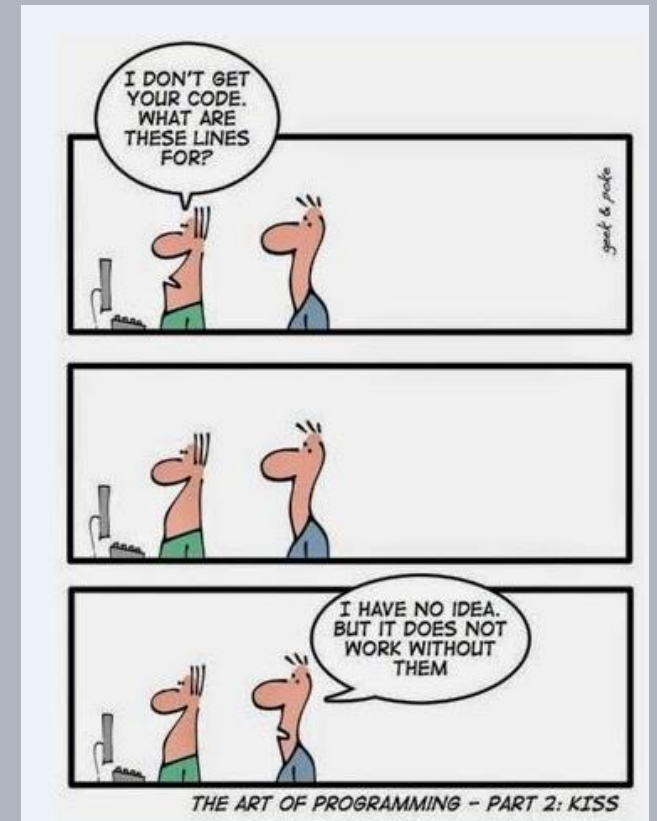


Advanced Software Design Techniques

Interface Design

Prof. Dr.-Ing. Peter Fromm



Content

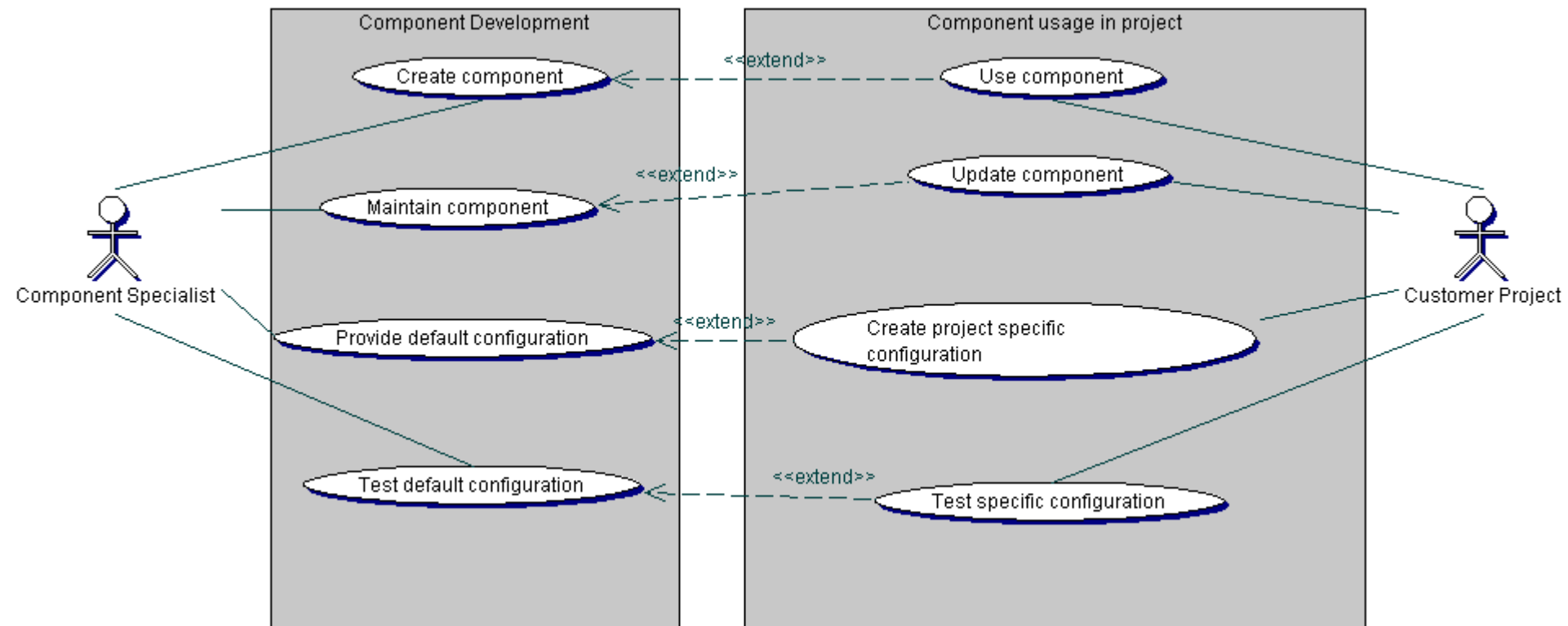
- Interface Design
 - Component Level
 - Class Level
 - Function Level
- Function Pointers and Functors
- Stubbing
- Component Configuration
- Release Processes



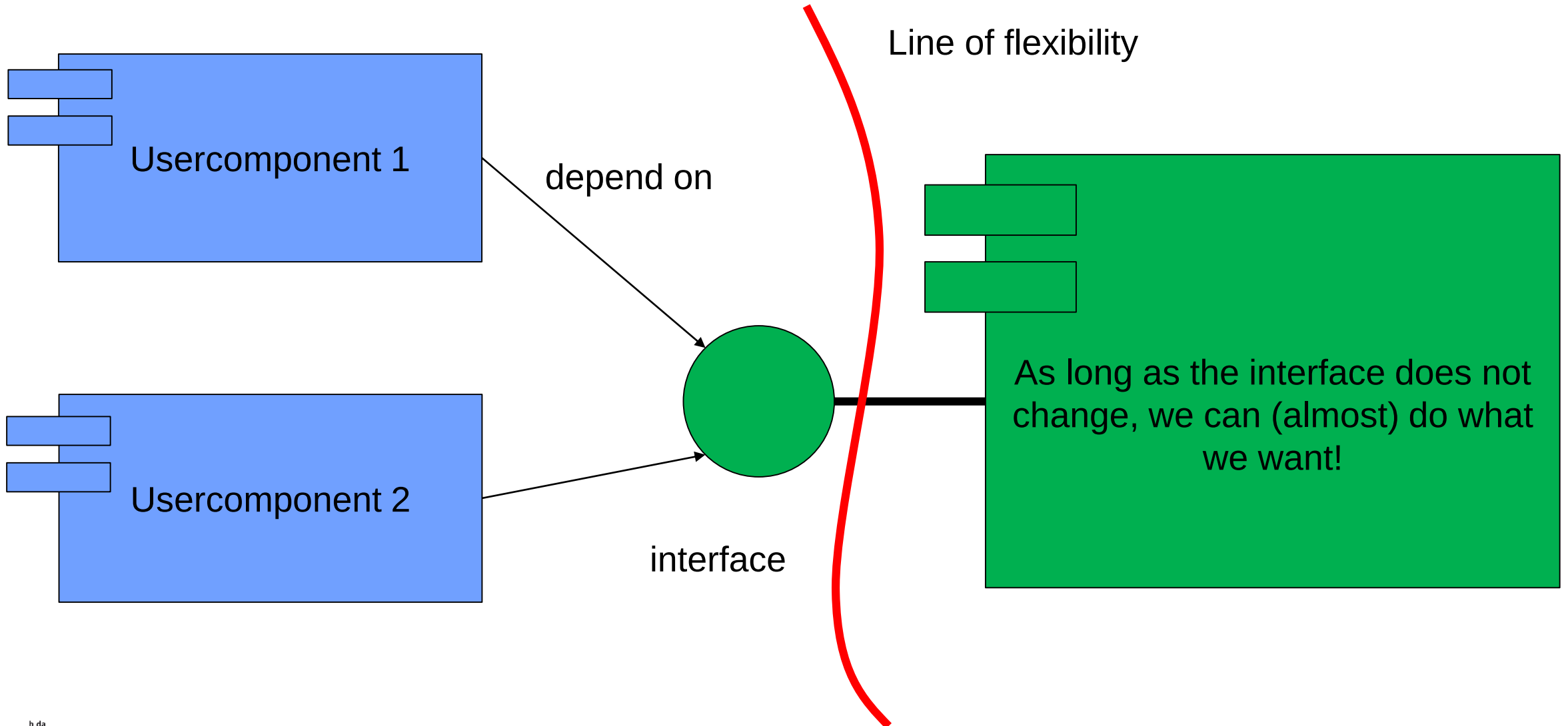
Component based development

In large companies, teams often work following a component based approach

- Usage shall be easy AND flexible
- Update shall be easy
- Additional tests shall be minimized



Importance of Interfaces



Some ideas about components and component reuse

Let's investigate this story first.

When are we willing to (re)use components?

- The component has to provide the required functionality - that's obvious
- The component usage shall be easy – that's more challenging
- The classes / sources which form the component must go through a release process
- The class releases must form a working component release. The classes have to be compatible!
- This implies a strong cohesion inside the component. It has to make sense, that these classes are released together.
- Finally, the developer will decide if he/she goes for a new release or not.
- This implies also a certain compatibility between the releases.

What makes an interface a good interface?

```
class CUart_v1
{
public:
    enum port_t{ASCLIN1, ASCLIN2, ASCLIN3,
                ASCLIN5, ASCLIN5, NONE};

    enum parity_t{ODD, EVEN, NONE};

    CUart_v1(port_t port = NONE,
              uint16_t baudrate = 115200,
              uint8_t bits = 8,
              parity_t parity = NONE,
              uint8_t stopbits = 1);
};
```

```
class CUart_v2
{
public:

    CUart_v2(uint16_t *const configReg,
              uint16_t *const baudReg1,
              uint16_t *const baudReg2,
              uint16_t configRegValue,
              int16_t baudReg1Value,
              uint16_t baudReg2Value);
};
```

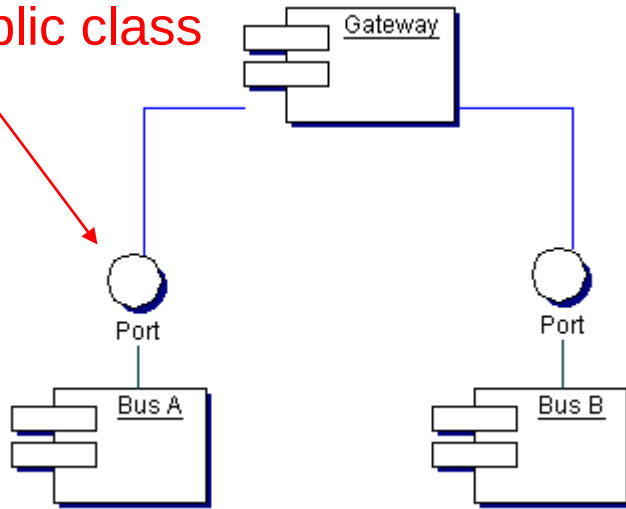
A good interface...

- Is **unique** in the system – there is no confusion, on whether it should be used or not
- Is **minimal** – only the required functions shall, be provided, making it easy to be understood
- Is **descriptive** – good names and types provide a clear usage guideline
- Is **abstract, hiding implementation** details – enabling the developer to change the implementation without affecting the interface.
- Is **robust and acting standalone** – there should be no hidden sideeffects / requirements when using it (i.e. function A has to be called before function B, otherwise B might crash), making it safe to be used
- Is **providing clear status information** – error conditions must be clearly returned



Different Levels of Interfaces

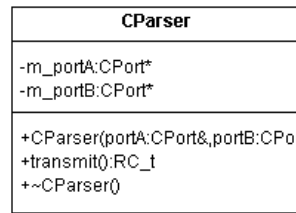
Public class



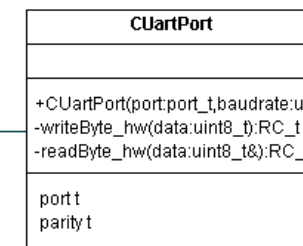
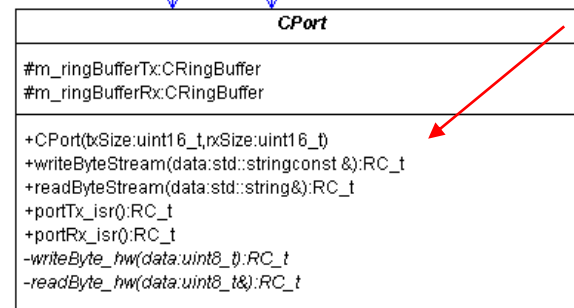
```

/**
 * \brief Constructor - Will initialize the peripheral port and setup the RX and TX buffers
 *
 * Constructor - Will initialize the peripheral port and setup the RX and TX buffers
 * Please check the hardware limitations to ensure proper configuration parameters
 *
 * \param port_t port = NONE : IN The hardware port to be used
 * \param uint16_t baudrate = 115200 : IN The baudrate of the device. Check the hardware manual for valid values.
 * \param uint8_t bits = 8 : IN The number of data bits, typically 7 or 8
 * \param parity_t parity = NONE : IN Parity, ODD, EVEN or NONE
 * \param uint8_t stopbits = 1 : IN Number of Stopbits, 1 or 2
 * \param uint16_t bufferSizeRx = UART_DEFAULTBUFFERSIZE : IN Size of the Receive Buffer
 * \param uint16_t bufferSizeTx = UART_DEFAULTBUFFERSIZE : IN Size of the Transmit Buffer
 */
CUartPort(port_t port = NONE,
          uint32_t baudrate = 115200,
          uint8_t bits = 8,
          parity_t parity = NOPARITY,
          uint8_t stopbits = 1,
          uint16_t bufferSizeRx = UART_DEFAULTBUFFERSIZE,
          uint16_t bufferSizeTx = UART_DEFAULTBUFFERSIZE
);
    
```

API Design



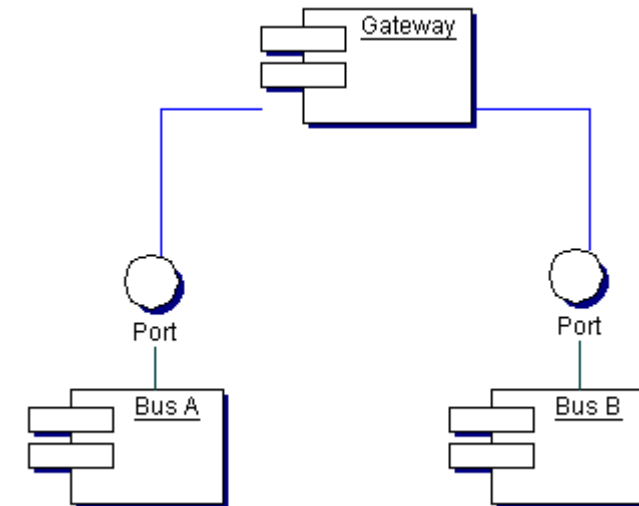
Public versus private methods



Design of a gateway system

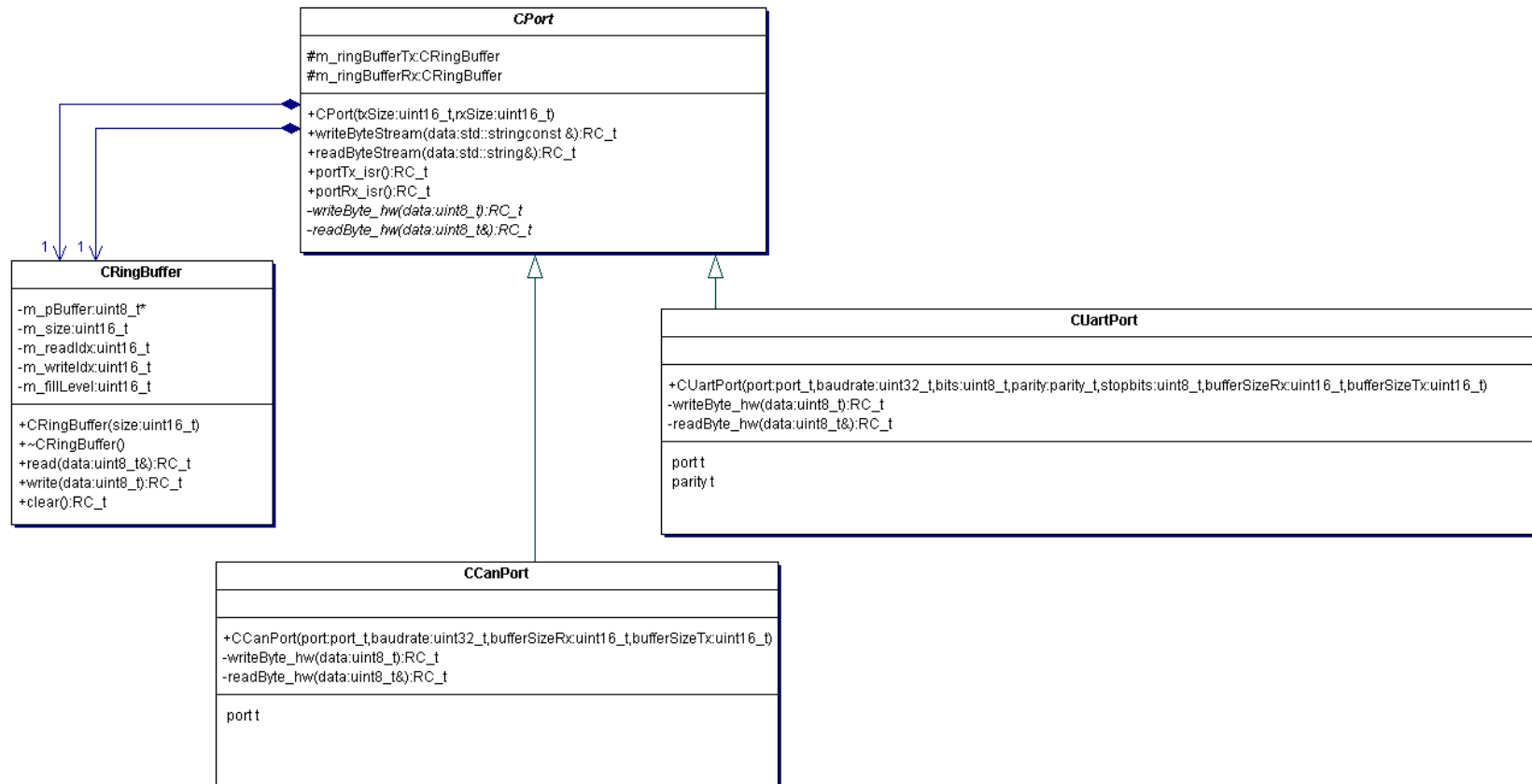
Component and Class Level

- The task of the gateway component is to read data from one bus, translate the protocol and send it out through another bus.
- The system should be flexible and support different hardware busses.
- Data transfer will be performed as bytestream (aka string).



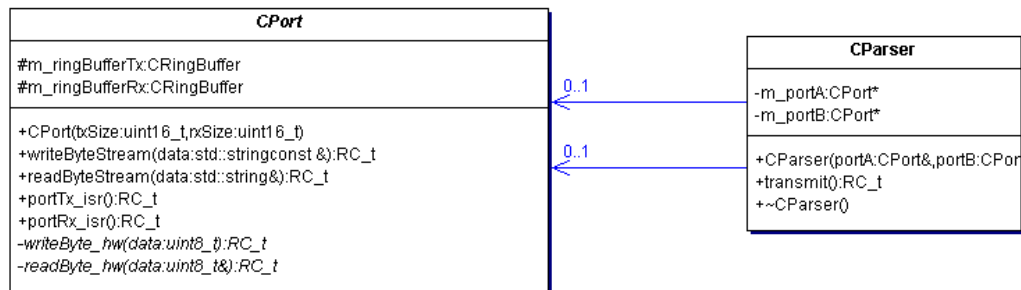
Class Design – Generic Port

- The system shall communicate through a generic port class, which will provide the interface
- A concrete class (in our example `CUartPort` and `CCanPort`) will provide the hardware related interfaces (but only those)



Port Component Usage

- Except for creating the physical devices, the user may ignore any hardware related parts.
- The parser itself only works with the CPort API's.



```
RC_t CParser::transmit()
{
    if (0 == m_portA || 0 == m_portB)
    {
        return RC_ERROR;
    }

    RC_t result = RC_ERROR;
    //Transmit from A to B
    string data;

    //Read the data
    result = m_portA->readByteStream(data);

    //Do something with the data

    //Write the data
    result = m_portB->writeByteStream(data);

    return result;
}
```

Dependency Issue

- But `main` (or any other class instantiating the hardware) has to include all physical devices – not so nice

```
#include "CPort.h"
#include "CParser.h"
#include "CUartPort.h"
#include "CCanPort.h"

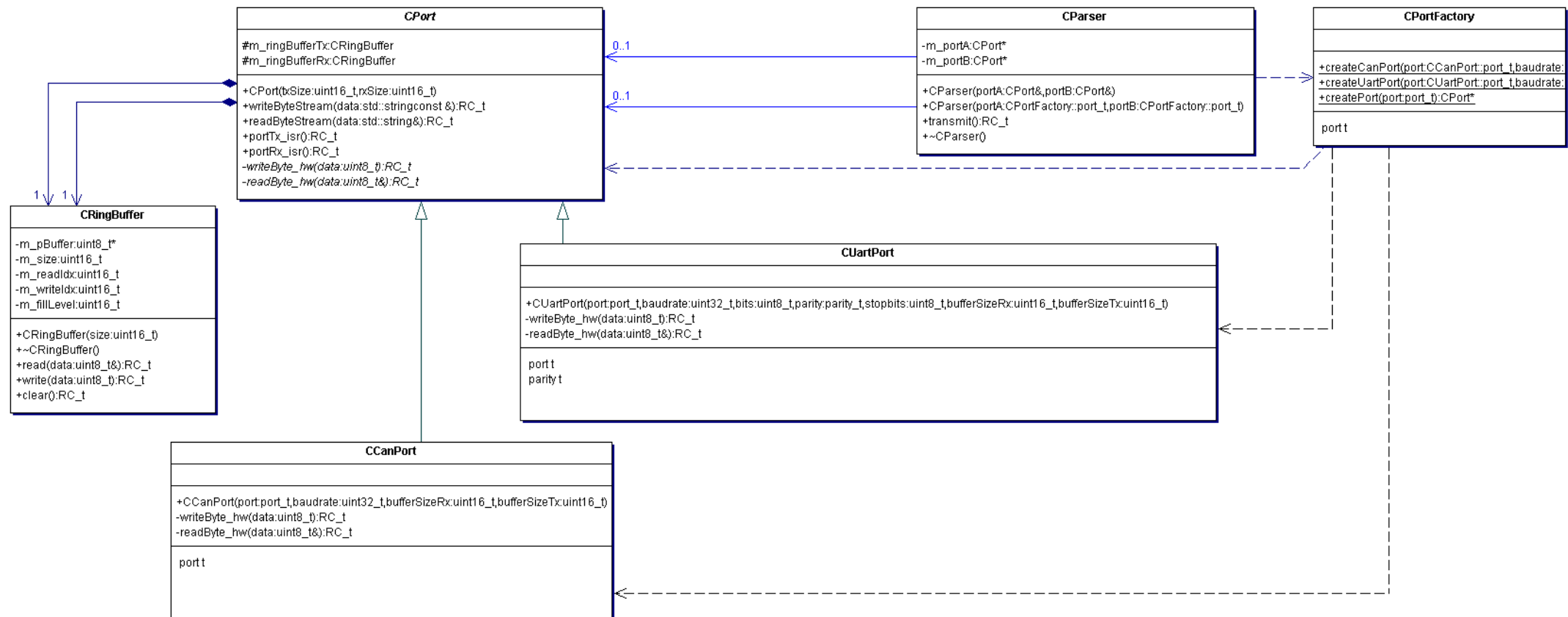
// Main program
int main (void)
{
    //Let's create the parser
    CUartPort uart;
    CCanPort can;

    CParser parser(uart, can);
    parser.transmit();

    return 0;
}
```

Let's introduce the Factory Pattern

- The job of the factory class is to provide specific objects.
- It encapsulates the dependencies to the specific classes, facilitating maintenance



Factory Pattern - Implementation

```
#include "CPort.h"
#include "CUartPort.h"
#include "CCanPort.h"

class CPortFactory {

public:

enum port_t{UART, CAN, NONE};

static CPort* createCanPort(
    CCanPort::port_t port = CCanPort::NONE,
    uint32_t baudrate = 1000000,
    uint16_t bufferSizeRx = CAN_DEFAULTBUFFERSIZE,
    uint16_t bufferSizeTx = CAN_DEFAULTBUFFERSIZE);

/**
 * Will create a port using the default configuration of the
 * port (i.e. the default parameters set above)
 */
static CPort* createPort(port_t port);

};
```

```
CPort* CPortFactory::createCanPort(CCanPort::port_t port,
    uint32_t baudrate, uint16_t bufferSizeRx, uint16_t
        bufferSizeTx)
{
    return new CCanPort(port, baudrate,bufferSizeRx, bufferSizeTx);
}

CPort* CPortFactory::createPort(port_t port)
{
    switch (port)
    {
        case UART: return createUartPort();
        case CAN: return createCanPort();
        default: /* Some error handling */ break;
    }

    return 0;
}
```

Interface Issue

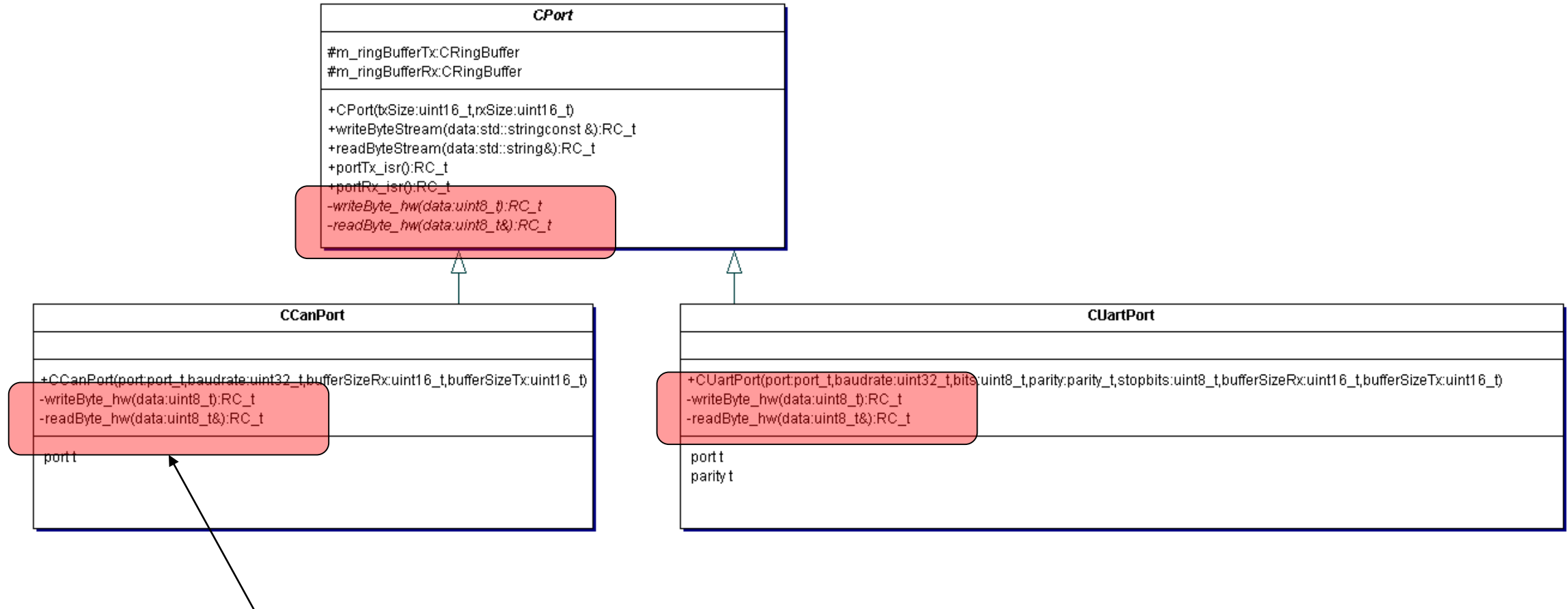
What can we do?

I guess we have violated the Liskov Substitution Principle?

We have a problem: UART takes a single byte, CAN takes 8. Ethernet even more?



Liskov Violation



Here, we would like to have a 8byte API

How could we improve the API

Solution 1 – We accept the 1 byte API

- Would require 8 calls and some internal buffering for the CAN
- Difficult to synchronise

Solution 2 – pass a `uint8_t` pointer

- The driver must know, how much data can be read
- Very efficient but dangerous. What happens if we want to transmit a single `uint32` over CAN?

Solution 3 – pass a stream object having an explicit length method

- Probably the best solution, as this is the common entity of a communication driver: transmit a specific number of bytes in one chunk
- Requires some extra effort
- But would also support a transport protocol (i.e. several packages transmitted one after the other)

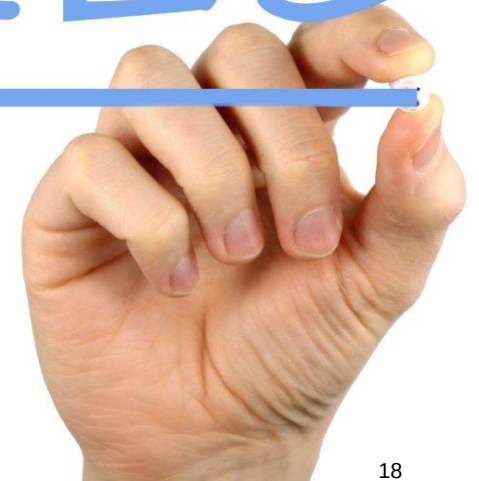


A deeper look at method interfaces

- Minimise the scope, consider public versus private functions
- Avoid global data for passing information
- Provide self explaining names
- Provide abstract parameters, hiding implementation details
- Make it const
- Prefer call by value versus reference versus pointer
- Consider parameter passing conventions from the compiler
- Don't forget error handling



RULES



Minimise the scope, consider public versus private functions

Goal

- Only functions / methods which should be called from the outside, should be made visible to the outside. This simplifies the usage of the module.
- This is also true for type definitions and data.

Recipe

- In C++, use private methods, type definitions and attributes
- In C, declare private types and functions in the C file (not Header). Use static data if needed.

Example

Statemachine.h

```
RC_t STATE_processEvent(EventType ev);
```

Statemachine.c

```
typedef enum {ISIDLE, ISPLAYING, ISRUNNING} STATE__state_t;  
  
static STATE__state_t STATE_state = ISIDLE;  
  
static void STATE__action1();  
static bool STATE__guard1();
```

Avoid global data for passing information

Goal

- Using global data for passing information obfuscates the signal flow, as the user cannot easily find out, where the data is written to.
- Furthermore global data is the number one reason for potential races in multithreading environments.

Recipe

- Use Parameters for passing information to and from functions.
- Use references or pointers if performance is a genuine issue.

Example

```
void calculateFilter()  
{  
    switch (filterType) {  
        case MEAN: ...
```

```
void calculateFilter(filter_t filterType)  
{  
    switch (filterType) {  
        case MEAN: ...
```

Data Scope

Goal

- Reduce the scope of data as much as possible
- This will reduce of obfuscated coupling and potential races.

Recipe

- Avoid global data at all (this will probably not work)
- Reduce the scope
- Provide API's to access global data
- Provide semaphores as needed.

Example

```
static speed_t POOL__speed = 0;

RC_t getSpeed(speed_t& speed)
{
    GetRessource(speed_ressource);
    speed = POOL__speed;
    ReleaseRessource(speed_resource);
}
```

extern global

file static global

function static attributes

class attributes

function locals

Provide self explaining names

Goal:

- There should be no confusion on how to call the function, even without reading the documentation
- Furthermore, good names help you to provide the correct content

Recipe

- Provide the name as mini sentence, consisting of a verb and a noun (recommended)
- Use CamelCase or _ to separate words
- Provide full parameter type AND and name in the API
- Introduce namespaces (Prefixes in C)

Examples

- `RC_t CParser::transmit()` versus `CParser::transmitFromPortAtoPortB()`
- `RC_t CRingBuffer::write(uint8_t data)`
- `CCanPort::CCanPort(port_t port, uint32_t baudrate, uint16_t bufferSizeRx, uint16_t bufferSizeTx)`
- `CCanPort::CCanPort(port_t , uint32_t, uint16_t, uint16_t)`

Provide self explaining names – Limitations and Solutions in C versus C++

C++ provide several layers of namespaces

- Global namespace (visible to everybody)
- Explicit namespace
- Class namespace
- Namespace::Class::Property

In C, we only have the global namespace

- Therefore we have to introduce own namespace by naming convention
- Add a prefix to every (non local) property

Example

- `GAME_processEvent()`
- `typedef enum {GAME__ISIDLE, GAME__ISRUNNING} GAME__state_t;`
- `static GAME__state_t GAME__state = GAME__ISIDLE;`

```
class Game
{
public:
    typedef enum {ISIDLE,
                  ISRUNNING} state_t
};

Game::state_t myState = Game::ISIDLE
```

Provide abstract parameters, hiding implementation details

Goal

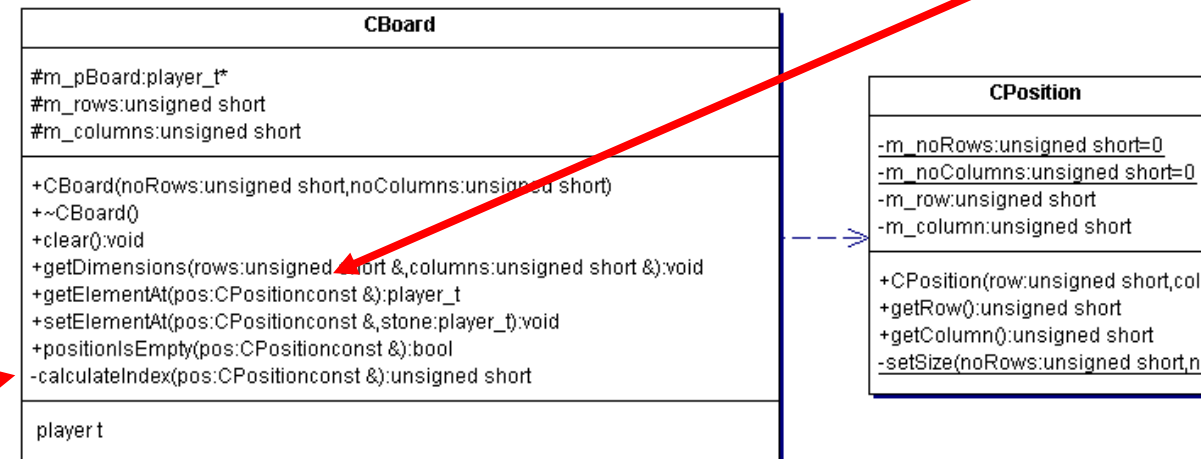
- The user shall be able to call the function without knowing (complex) internal details
- The module responsible shall be able to modify the internal behaviour without changing the API

Recipe

- Consider functionality and ignore implementation details when designing the API
- Use internal (private) methods to translate abstract parameters into implementation specific format
- Use abstract data types, supporting maintainability

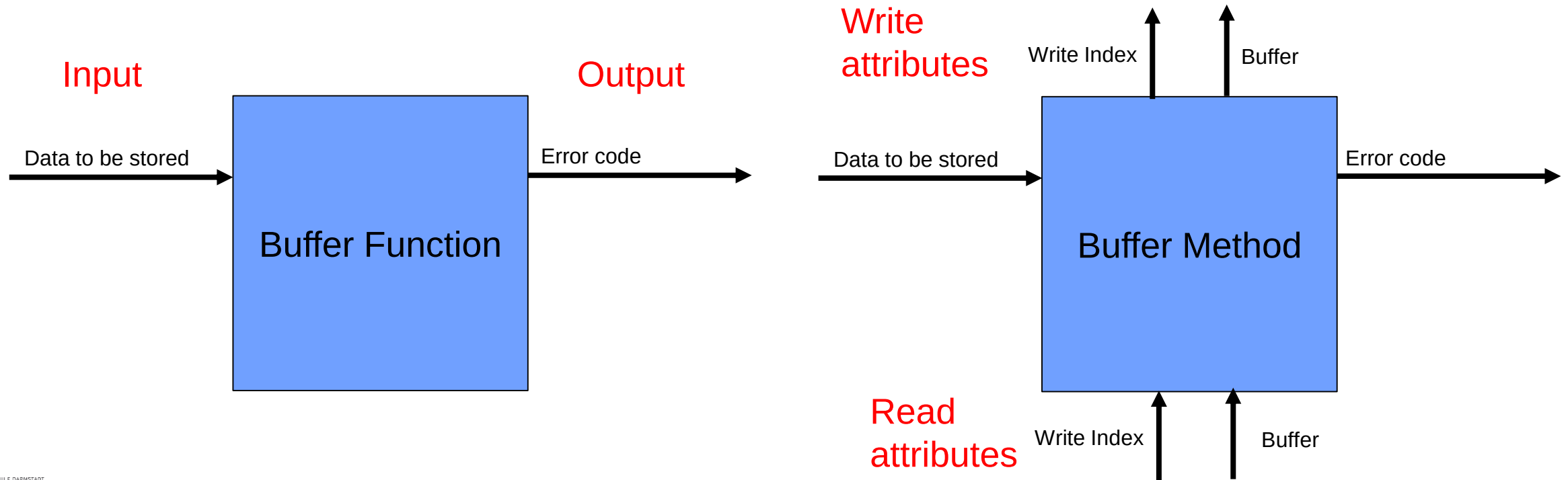
Examples

- `getElementAt(CPosition pos)`
- `getElementAt(uint16_t row, uint16_t col)`
- `getElementAt(uint16_t index)`



Interface Diagram

- Supports interface design in an abstract way
- Focussing on information flow, not implementation details
- Types may be added later (optional)
- Technical details like pointer, reference etc. may be added later (optional)



Make it const

Goal

- Accidental modification of data may cause system failures and is hard to debug.
- Therefore data, which is not intended to be modified, should be declared as const

Recipe

- Const comes in two different flavours
 - Data is linked into flash (making it really const)
 - The compiler is instructed not to modify data -creating compiler errors in case of violations.
Problem: this const data can be casted into non-const data or modified by pointers and therefore is not 100% safe.

Examples

- `const int calibrationCurve[] = {1,2,2,2,4,4,5,6,7,7,7}; //Very likely placed in flash`
- `void writeData(data_t const& data); //data reference should not be modified`

Make it const

```
//parameter data may not be changed inside the function
```

```
void foo(int const data)
```

```
//reference to parameter data may not be changed inside the function. Reference is used as read only
```

```
void foo(int const& data)
```

```
//Pointer address and dereferenced value may not be changed. Data is passed read only
```

```
void foo(int const * const data)
```

```
//Pointer address is constant but dereferenced value may be changed. Data is passed read / write
```

```
void foo(int * const data)
```

```
//Returned data may not be modified. E.g. for protecting a reference
```

```
const data_t& getSomeData()
```

```
//Method does not modify the object, i.e. method works with const and non-const objects
```

```
void class::foo() const
```

Const refers to the left hand type, unless this does not make sense. In this case, the right hand type is taken.

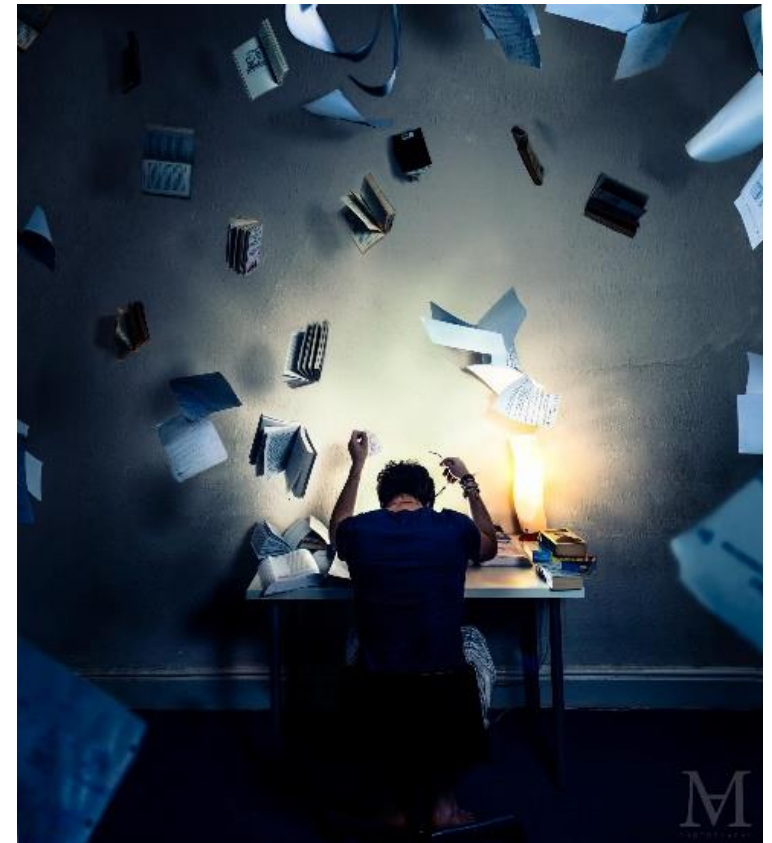
Make it const

Changing a non-const type to a const type during refactoring is frustrating

- May compilation errors
- Sequences of const's are required in many files

Therefore

- Introduce const right away from the start of the project
- Make methods const if they do not modify the object



Prefer call by value versus reference versus pointer

Goal

- Call by reference and call by pointer are more performant, but may have side effects. They are not re-entrant and data accidentally may be overwritten.

Recipe

- For small data types, which fit into a register, a call by value should be used
- For larger datatypes a const& is the preferred approach (unless re-entrance is required)
- Pointers should only be used if references are not available or if the architectures requires it (e.g. to support NULL pointers in case of late associations)

Examples

- `void foo(uint16_t data) //Safe, re-entrant and no benefit when using references or pointers`
- `void foo(largeData_t const& data) //Fast, but special care needed in case of re-entrance`

Consider parameter passing conventions from the compiler

Goal

- Depending of the compiler and architecture, different conventions may be valid for passing parameters. This may have a significant impact on runtime.

Recipe

- Passing data by register is efficient.
- Passing large data structure by stack slows the execution down
- Multiple calls of copy and assignment operators slow the operation down

Examples

- ```
void foo (class_t data) { m_data = data;}
```

```
//Will use the copy constructor to copy the data on the stack
```

```
//Then the local variable will be copied into the attribute
```
- ```
void foo (uint32_t d1, uint32_t d2, uint32_t d3, uint32_t d4,
```

```
uint32_t d5)
```



```
//d1 until d4 will be passed by register on most 32bit machines
```

```
//d5 will require an expensive stack operation
```

Don't forget error handling

Goal

- Any function must ensure a safe operation under all conditions. In case a fault cannot be handled, it must be reported to the next “responsibility level”, the caller.

Recipe

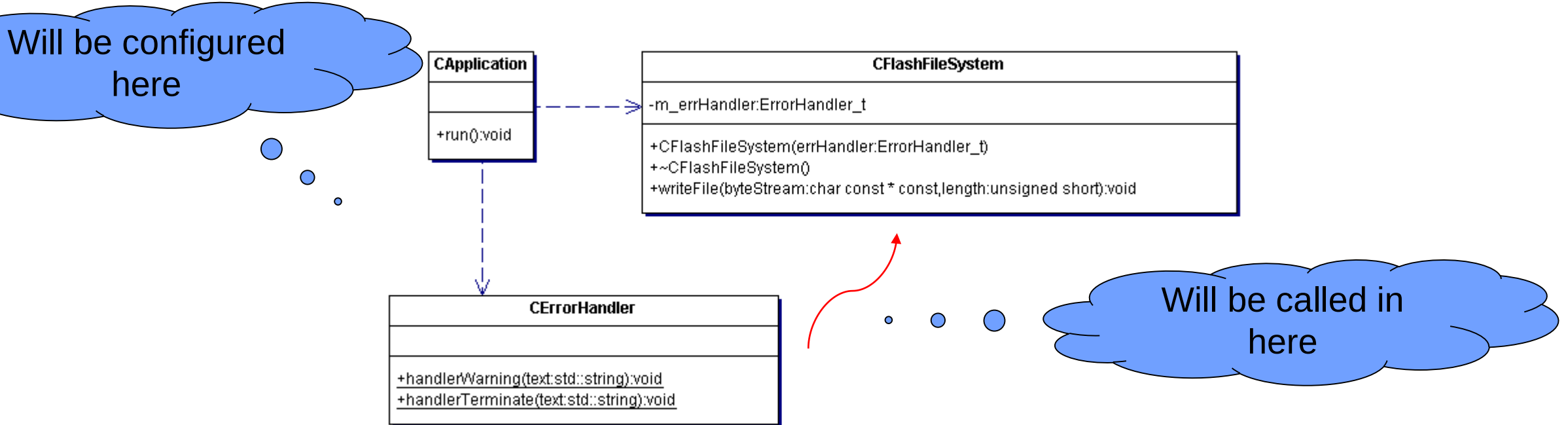
- Provide error handling for all functions, which might throw an error (very likely almost all)
- Define a common error handling concept as part of the architecture

Examples

- ```
RC_t foo(uint16_t value) { if (0 == value) return RC_BADPARAM; }
```

# Function Pointers and Functors

- Let's assume, we are implementing a function, which is writing data on a flash disc.
- Depending on the application, different error handlers shall be called.
- We do not want to rely on the user to use the return value properly (as most programmers tend to ignore return values).
- Instead, the user shall provide a callback function, which will implement the error handler.





# Function Pointer Declaration

```
class CFlashFileSystem
{
public:
/**
 * Function Pointer for the error handler
 */
typedef void (*ErrorHandler_t) (std::string errorMessage);

private:
ErrorHandler_t m_errHandler;

public:

CFlashFileSystem(ErrorHandler_t errHandler);

virtual ~CFlashFileSystem();

void writeFile(char const *const byteStream, unsigned short length);
};
```

# Function Pointer Call

```
CFlashFileSystem::CFlashFileSystem(ErrorHandler_t errorHandler)
{
 m_errHandler = errorHandler;
}
```

```
CFlashFileSystem::~~CFlashFileSystem()
{
 m_errHandler = 0;
}
```

```
void CFlashFileSystem::writeFile(const char *const byteStream,
unsigned short length)
{
```

```
//Todo: check for valid errorHandler;
```

```
if (0 == byteStream) {
 m_errHandler("Wrong param - byteStream points to 0");
}
```

```
if (0 == length) {
 m_errHandler("Wrong param - nothing to write, length is 0");
}
```

# Handler Implementation

```
void CErrorHandler::handlerWarning(std::string text)
{
 cerr << "Error: " << text << endl;
}
```

```
void CErrorHandler::handlerTerminate(std::string text)
{
 cout << "Error: " << text << endl;
 terminate();
}
```

# Functors

- In addition to function pointers, C++ provides so called **function objects**, aka functors.
- Basically, this is nothing but an overloaded () operator, which makes the class object behave like a function.
- The overloaded () can be considered to be the most flexible operator, as it imposes no limitations on the number and type of arguments.
- Also the return type is user defined.
- As compared to ordinary function pointers, a function object may contain additional attributes, reflecting an internal state of the function.
- Furthermore these attributes may be set when calling the constructor.



# Error handler class using functors

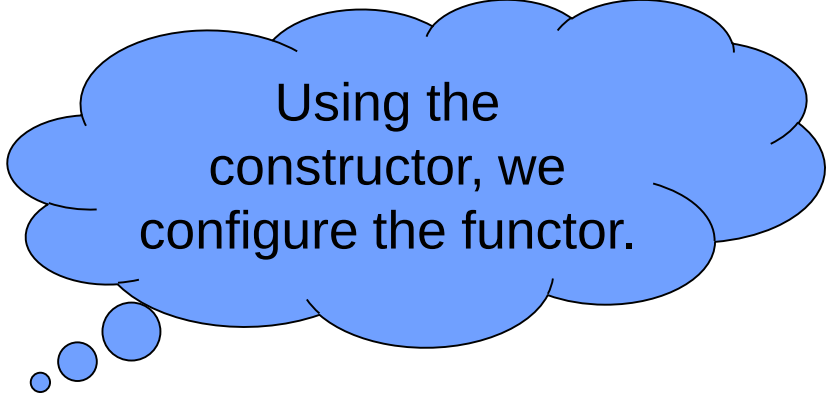
```
class CFuncторErrorHandler
{
private:
 bool m_terminateOnError;
public:
 CFuncторErrorHandler(bool terminateOnError = true);

 void operator()(std::string msg);
};

CFuncторErrorHandler::CFuncторErrorHandler(bool terminateOnError)
{
 m_terminateOnError = terminateOnError;
}

void CFuncторErrorHandler::operator ()(std::string msg)
{
 cerr << "ERROR: " << msg << endl;

 if (true == m_terminateOnError) {
 terminate();
 }
}
```



Using the constructor, we configure the functor.

## Calling it in the application

```
void CFlashSystemFunctor::writeFile(const char *const byteStream,
unsigned short length)
{
//Todo: check for valid errorHandler;

if (0 == byteStream) {
 m_errHandler("Wrong param - byteStream points to 0");
}

if (0 == length) {
 m_errHandler("Wrong param - nothing to write, length is 0");
}
}
```

Advantage of the functor – the termination logic is encapsulated in the class, reducing the user flexibility a bit. Which sometimes is not too bad!

# Mixing Function Pointers and Functors

- Although functors share the signature of ordinary function pointers, they cannot be exchanged. For this, we will need the argument deduction of templates.

```
template <class T>
void functionTakingAnyErrorHandler(int paramA, int paramB, T errHdl)
{
 if (0 == paramA)
 {
 errHdl("A was 0");
 }

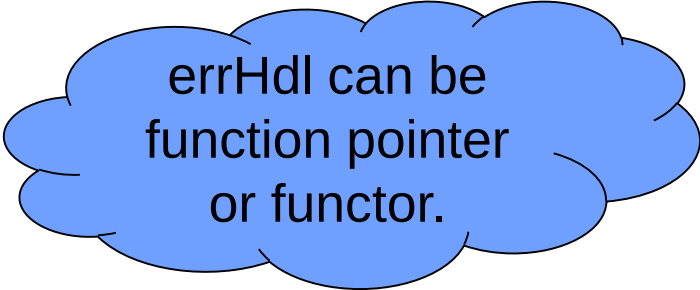
 if (0 == paramB)
 {
 errHdl("B was 0");
 }
}
```

//Using Fuction Pointers

```
functionTakingAnyErrorHandler(0,0,CErrHandler::handlerWarning);
functionTakingAnyErrorHandler(0,0,CErrHandler::handlerTerminate);
```

//Using Functors

```
functionTakingAnyErrorHandler(0,0, CFunctorErrorHandler(false));
functionTakingAnyErrorHandler(0,0, CFunctorErrorHandler(true));
```



errHdl can be  
function pointer  
or functor.

# Functors and Polymorphism?

- We might create a error handling base class, defining the functor API
- And then allow the user to implement specialised error handling classes
- The application code will call the base class Functor
- Which will call specialised error handlers if required.



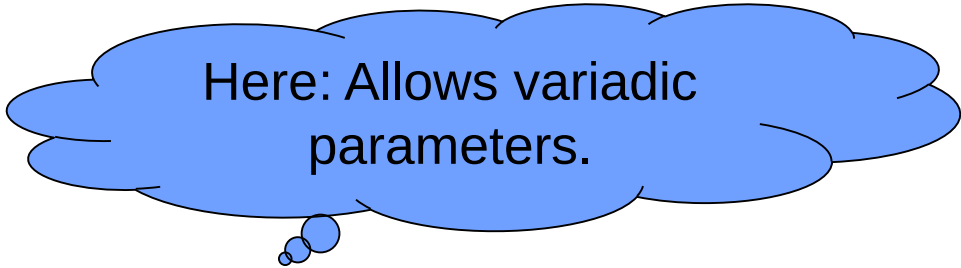


## How about Lambda's

- C++11 introduces lambdas allowing you to write an inline, anonymous functor to replace the explicit class declaration.
- Good for e.g. filters and similar “small logic”
- Example: Deadline Monitoring of runnables having different API's

```
int MonitorStart(int p_ret, RC_t (*p_run)())
{
 PxExpectAbort(RunWrapper, p_ret, p_run);
 return 0;
}

void RunWrapper(int* p_ret, R (*p_run)())
{
 *p_ret = p_run();
}
```



Here: Allows variadic parameters.

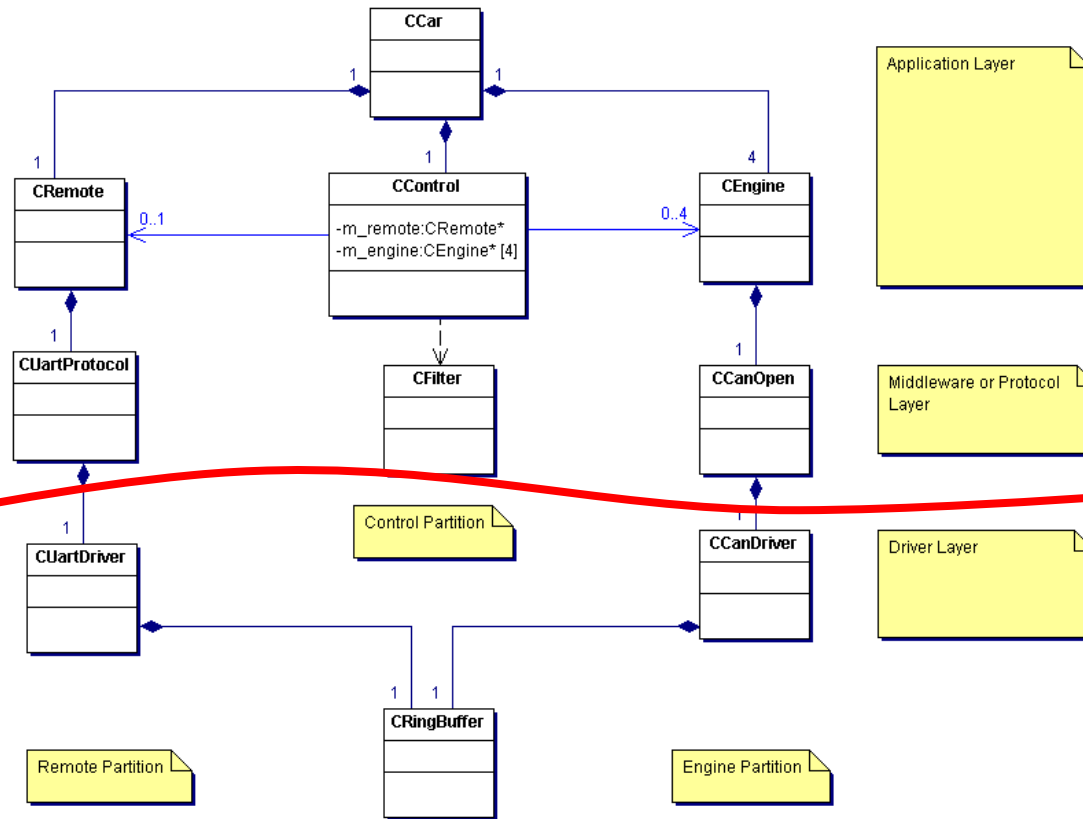
```
int retVal;
MonitorStart(&retVal, []() -> int {return RunDiverse(2, 3.0f, 'c');});
```

# Let's come back to earth....



# Stubbing

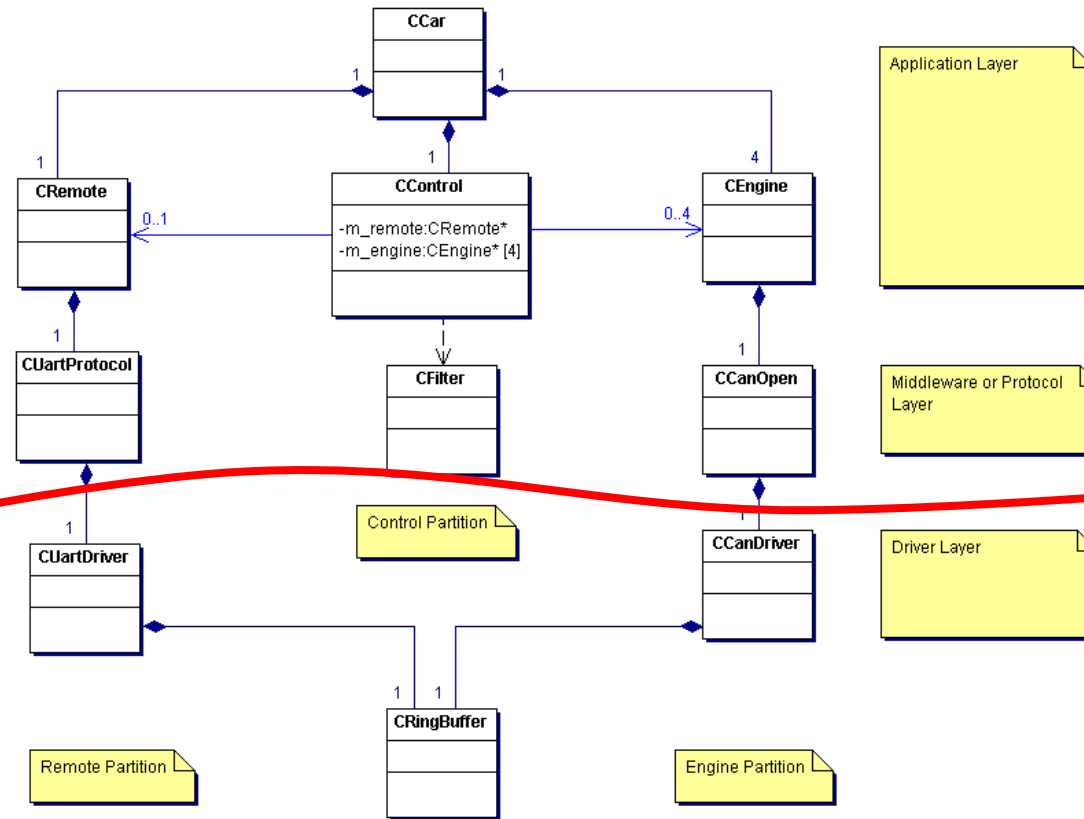
Requires  
agreed API!



Very likely, the drivers will not be present upon project start. Instead, we can agree on the API and use stubs instead.

# Stubbing

SIL: This part can be developed and tested on a PC instead of an embedded target. Much faster!

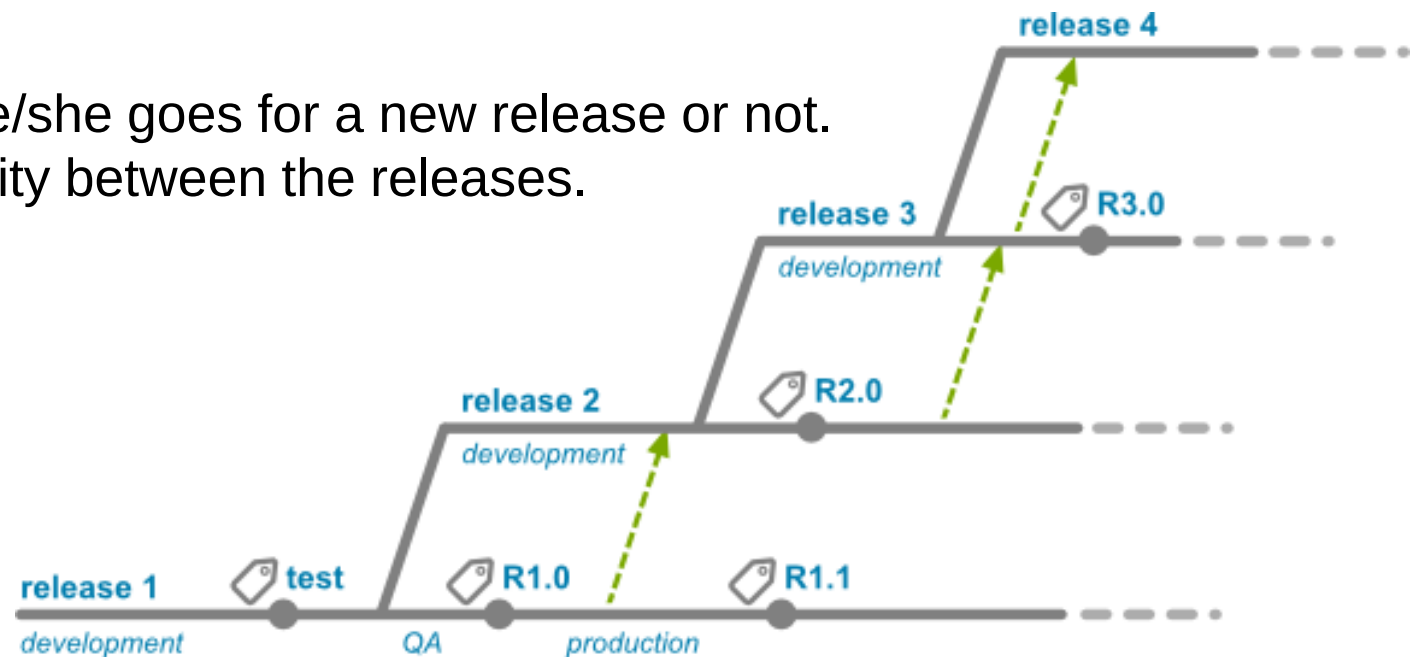


Provide simulated drivers on PC side. This also allows to test functionality, but probably not the timing aspects, memory, full error handling...

# Release process

Remember....

- The classes / sources which form the component must go through a release process
- The class releases must form a working component release. The classes have to be compatible!
- This implies a strong cohesion inside the component. It has to make sense, that these classes are released together.
- Finally, the developer will decide if he/she goes for a new release or not.
- This implies also a certain compatibility between the releases.



## The Common Closure Principle

- Only classes, which change for the same reason and at the same time should be placed into a component.
- Classes, that change for different reasons or at different times should be placed in separate components.

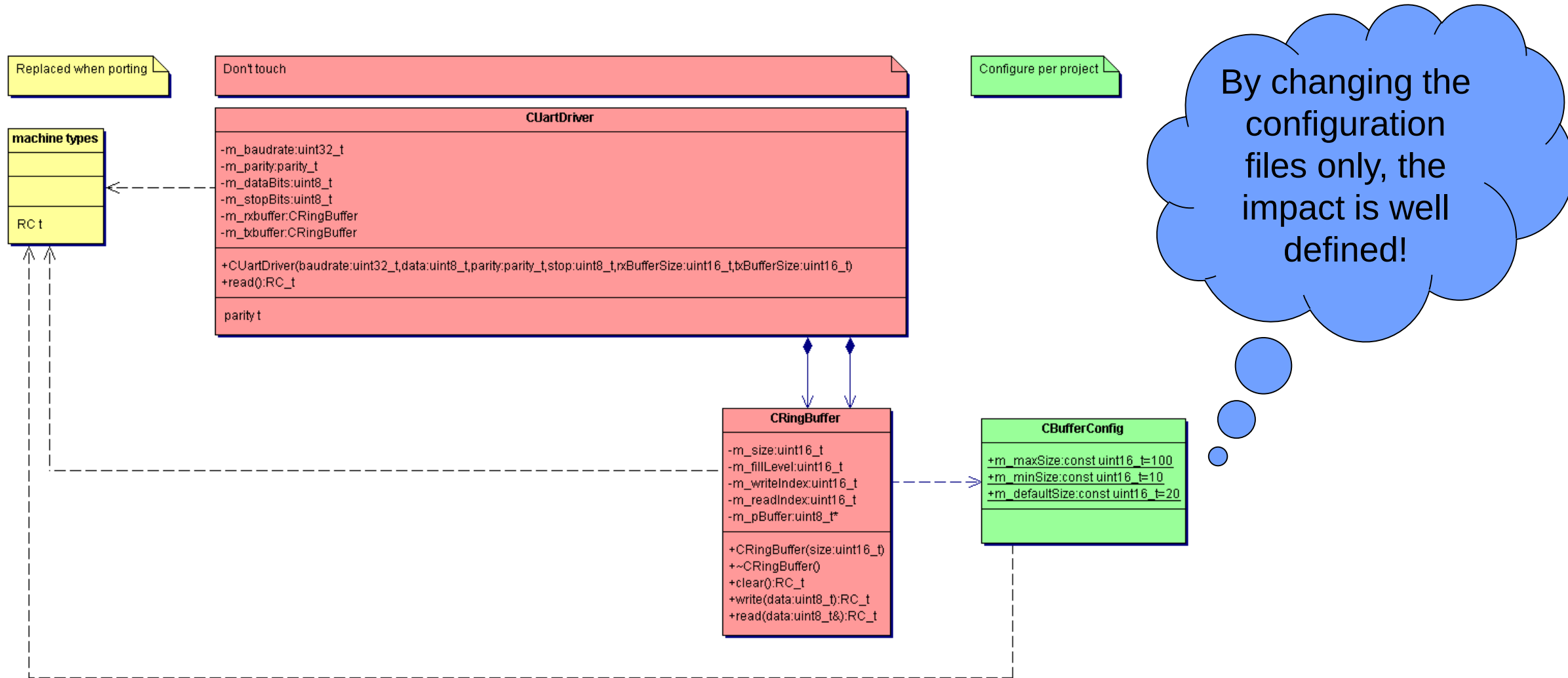
Same is true for class design. A good example is the separated configuration of a class!

# Configurations and Variants

Until now, the main concept for generalisation and specialisation was inheritance. However, there are way more options:

- Configuration by parameters (e.g. constructor) → valid for a specific object
- Separation of specific configuration parts (enums, #defines, const tables) in own files → valid for the complete class (i.e. all objects)
- Classes, sharing similar behaviour but different data structure → Templates

# Configuration Files





# Project Level versus User Level Configuration

This parameter is configured by the individual user (per object)

```
CRingBuffer::CRingBuffer(uint16_t size)
{
 if (size >= CBufferConfig::m_minSize && size < CBufferConfig::m_maxSize)
 {
 m_size = size;
 }
 else
 {
 m_size = CBufferConfig::m_defaultSize;
 }

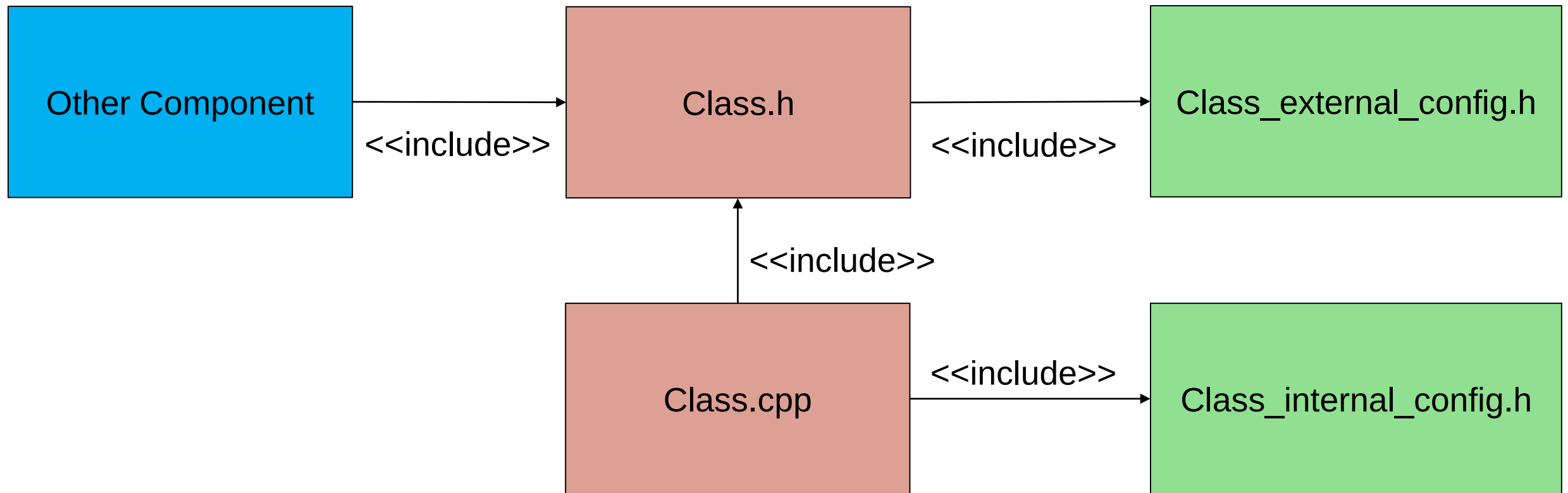
 m_fillLevel = 0;
 m_readIndex = 0;
 m_writeIndex = 0;

 m_pBuffer = new uint8_t[m_size];
}
```

This is a constraint on class / project level. May be different for different projects.

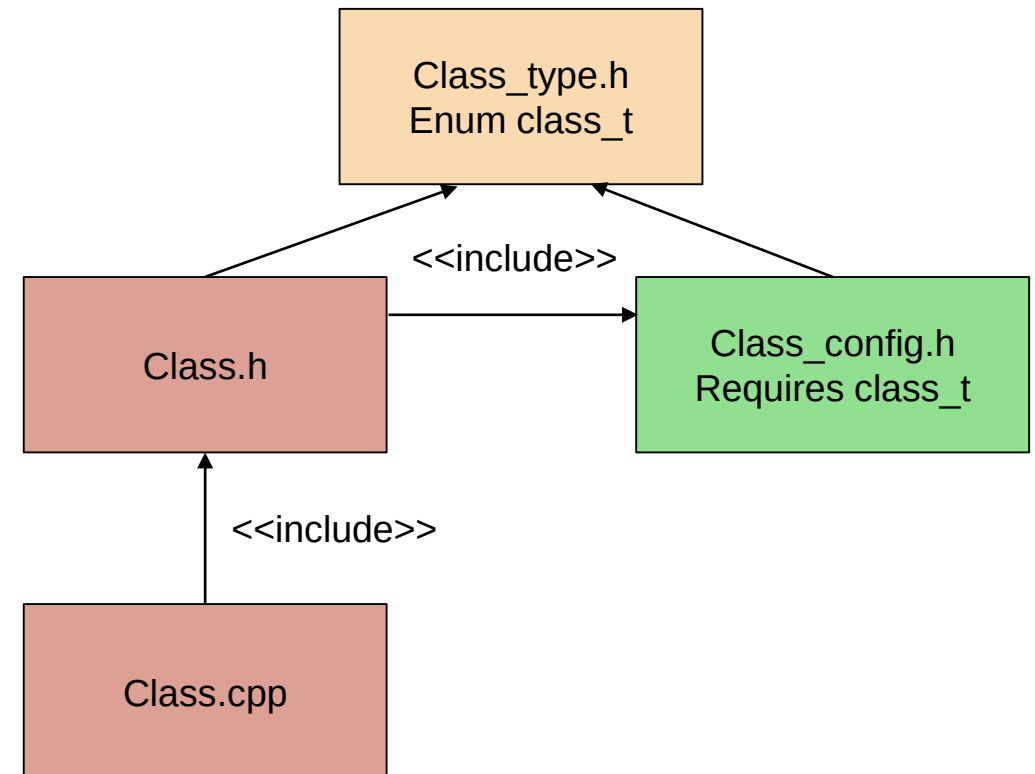
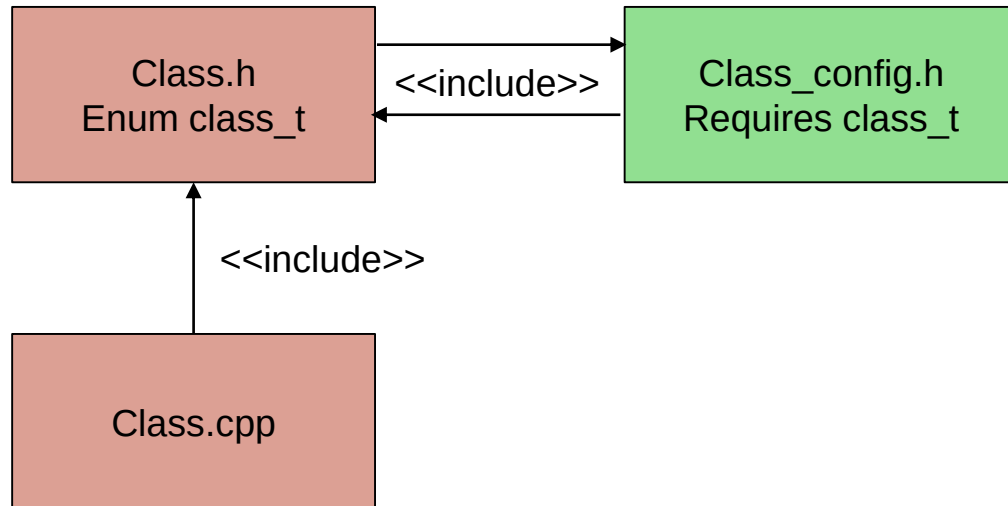
## Configuration Files – Internal versus External Configuration

Some configurations should be visible to the complete project, other configurations should be private for the component.

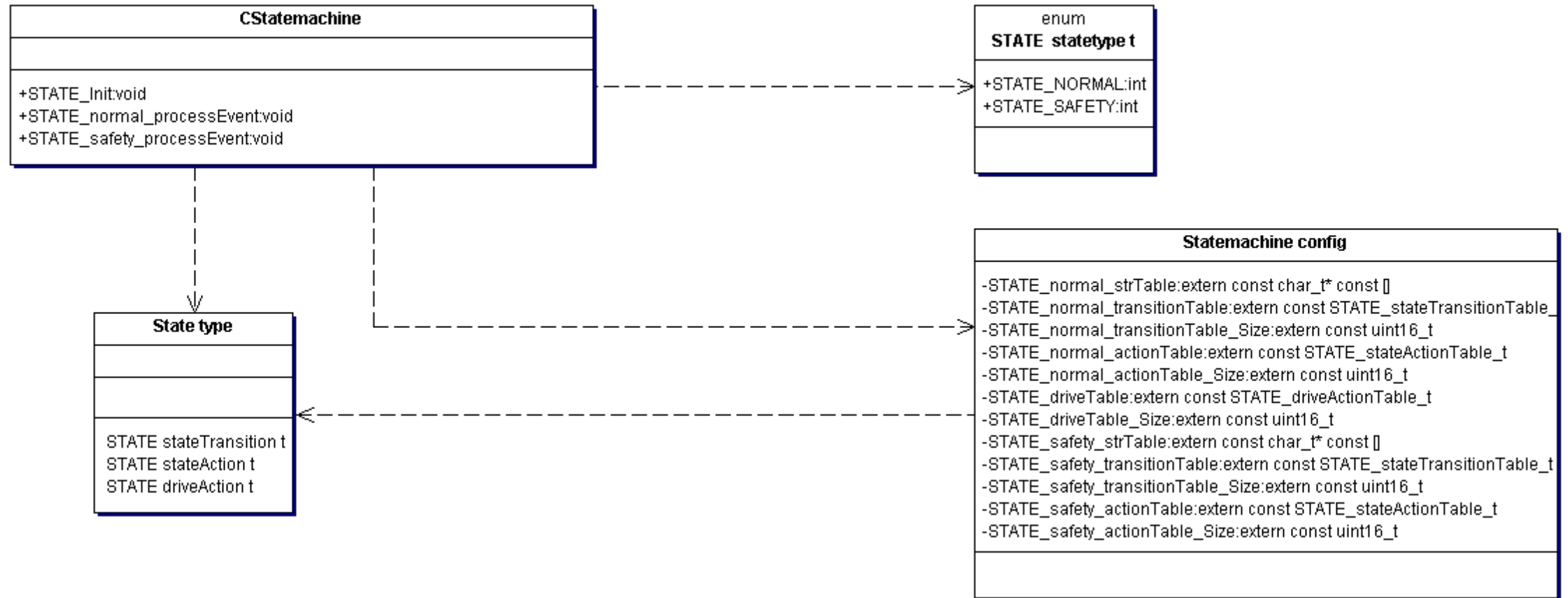


## Separation of Type Headers

- Very often, a foreign component or a configuration class requires some type definitions of another components, e.g. enum values. To avoid circular dependencies, these can be placed in an extra file.
- Also speeds up compilation, as only the type file is included!



# Configuration Files Containing Code





## Another example

Let's consider a generic PID controller for an engine...

Which parts must be configurable?

- Constant Data
- Changing Data
- Data Types
- Behaviour
- API restrictions (e.g. from a generated driver?)



# Wrapup

- Interface design on component, class as function level
- Golden rules for API design
- Function parameters or functors adding flexibility
- Separating configuration parts